



BOOM TIME: More women are now heading for baby makers

Baby BLOOM

■ By Purvi Malhotra

Every woman is born with the gift to give birth and when that gift is taken away, it leaves a huge void. With India's population of a billion and ticking, being anxious for a baby sounds absurd. But the figures say it all: of 200 million people in the reproductive stage, 10 per cent are infertile, pushing the number of in-vitro fertilisation treatment (IVF) cycles from 7,273 in 2001 to 19,005 in 2005, according to the National ART (artificial reproduction technologies) registry of India.

Gynaecologist Suyashree Vikas Palkar, 41, spent 10 years trying for a child. She couldn't conceive naturally because of endometriosis, where tissue similar to the uterus lining is found elsewhere in the body. Thirty to 40 per cent women with endometriosis are infertile. Palkar went for her first IVF in Belfast, Ireland. It failed. Back in India, she went through three more cycles that failed too. IVF begins with injections given for 30 days and a 14-day wait after the embryos are planted in the womb. "Post 35, the ovarian reserve and the quality of eggs decrease in women, making natural conception difficult,"

Nothing is permanent in the new India, not even the idea that motherhood is an impossible dream for some women

says Ilrishikesh Pai, infertility specialist, Lilavati Hospital, Mumbai. The treatment costs between Rs 60,000 and Rs 1.25 lakh for one cycle and the success rate is as low as 34.2 per cent. With four to five embryos implanted at every cycle, conceiving multiple children is possible. In 2002, Palkar struck lucky with Fizuza Parikh, director, Department of Assisted Reproduction and Genetics, Jaslok Hospital, when she got pregnant with twins, but the older twin died during pregnancy. She conceived her second son in 2004 by the cumulus-aided-transfer, that increases the chances of IVF conception in older women. Even with sophisticated IVF techniques, there are chances it may not work. In these cases, surrogacy has been a ray of light. In 2005, the number of IVF cycles in surrogate mothers was 177, with a 38 per cent success rate.

Even with changing lifestyles, the desire for natural progeny remains. And with baby makers, women are ready to go the extra mile to achieve it. ■

KAMINI RAO, infertility specialist, 1993

"Earlier people accepted infertility as their lot. Now they are trying treatment."